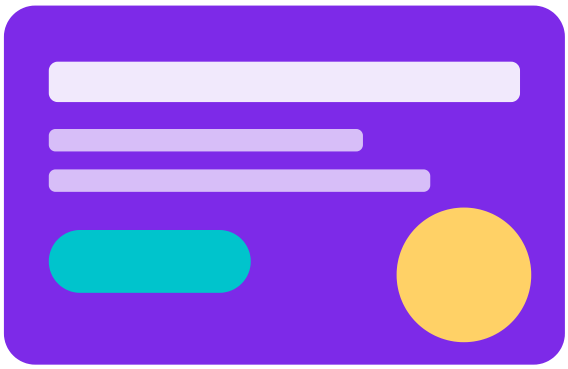
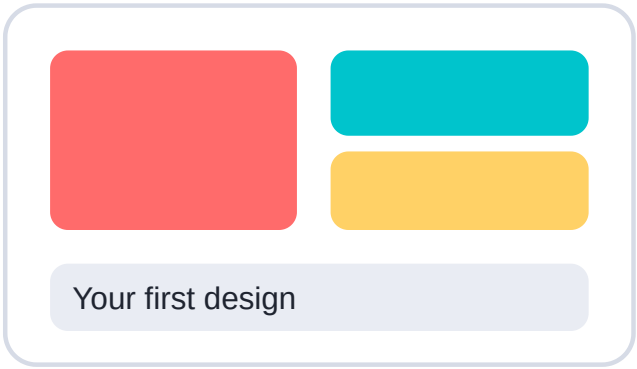
A PRACTICAL COURSE · ENGLISH · 2026 EDITION

Canva from Zero to a Digital Freelance Career

How to use Canva, create your account, build real design skills, find clients, and use what you learn on other platforms too.





Who it is for
A beginner with basic computer skills (typing, files, browsing, email).

Time needed
About 6 to 8 weeks at 1 hour a day, plus practice.

What you will need
A laptop or desktop, internet, one email address, a notebook.

Canva changes its screens, menus and plans from time to time. Where exact prices or menu names matter, this course tells you what to check on canva.com. Always confirm current details before you rely on them.

How to Use This Course

This course takes you from opening Canva for the first time to earning money from design work online. It is arranged in fourteen chapters. Read them in order the first time. Later you can jump to any chapter you need.

Each chapter has three kinds of boxes:

Tip. A shortcut or a habit that saves time or improves your work.

Careful. A mistake that beginners often make, or a legal or money point you must not skip.

Exercise. A short task to do before moving on. Doing exercises is the fastest way to learn Canva.

Three rules for learning design

1. **Make something every day,** even a small one. Skill comes from making, not from watching.
2. **Keep your files.** Name each design with the date and project, for example *2026-11-10 Cafe Menu v2*. Your portfolio will grow from these files.
3. **Ask for feedback.** Show your work to one or two people who are not your family and ask what is confusing.

Contents

1	Welcome to the Digital Design Economy	Chapter 1
2	Getting to Know Canva	Chapter 2
3	Creating Your Canva Account	Chapter 3
4	Walking Through the Canva Editor	Chapter 4
5	Design Fundamentals You Can Apply in Canva	Chapter 5
6	Hands-On Projects	Chapter 6
7	Advanced Canva and Magic Studio	Chapter 7
8	Building a Portfolio and Personal Brand	Chapter 8
9	Pricing, Finding Clients and Communicating	Chapter 9
10	Freelance Marketplaces	Chapter 10
11	Selling Templates and Digital Products	Chapter 11
12	Similar Platforms and Transferable Skills	Chapter 12
13	Running Your Freelance Business	Chapter 13
14	Your 90-Day Roadmap, Glossary and Checklist	Chapter 14

CHAPTER 1

Welcome to the Digital Design Economy

1.1 Why design skills sell today

Almost every business now needs visual content: posts for social media, flyers for events, menus for restaurants, slides for sales meetings, certificates for schools, and product photos for online shops. Most small businesses cannot afford an in-house designer, and many do not know how to use professional software. That gap is your opportunity.

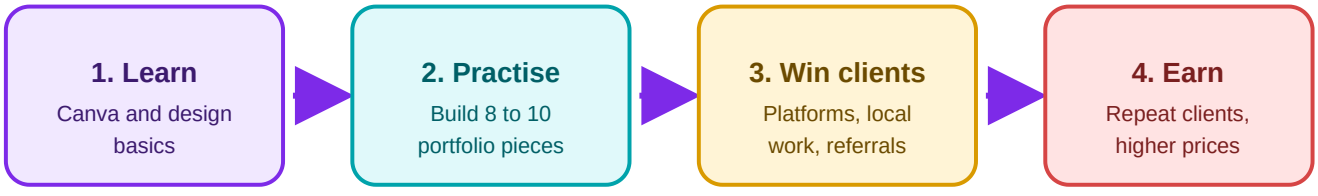
You do not need to be a trained artist to earn from design. Clients pay for *clear, attractive, on-time results*. A tool such as Canva lets a motivated beginner produce work that looks professional, because the tool supplies good fonts, layouts and colours. Your value is in choosing well, arranging well and understanding what the client needs.

1.2 What a digital freelancer does

A digital freelancer sells a service online and delivers it remotely. Common services for a Canva-based designer include:

Service	What the client gets	Typical buyer
Social media graphics	A monthly set of posts, stories and reels covers	Shops, clinics, coaches, restaurants
Print design	Flyers, posters, brochures, menus, business cards	Local businesses, events, schools
Presentations	Pitch decks, reports, training slides	Startups, consultants, teachers
Document design	Resumes, proposals, certificates, invoices	Job seekers, companies, NGOs
Template creation	Editable designs that clients can change themselves	Agencies, online sellers, educators
Simple video	Short animated posts and promo clips	Creators, small brands

1.3 The career path in one picture



Most people spend 2 to 4 months moving from step 1 to the first paid job.

Figure 1.1 The four stages of a digital design career.

1.4 Realistic expectations

Income from freelancing usually starts small and grows over several months. Your first few jobs may be cheap because you are building reviews and confidence. Plan for a gap between starting and earning. Keep a regular

job or other income while you learn, if you can. Treat the first year as an apprenticeship: every project teaches you about clients, deadlines and money.

Careful. Be wary of anyone who promises a fixed monthly income after a short course, or asks you to pay them to "unlock" clients. Legitimate training does not guarantee earnings.

Exercise 1. Write one paragraph answering: "Which two services would I most like to sell, and who would buy them from me?" Keep it; you will use it in Chapter 9.

CHAPTER 2

Getting to Know Canva

2.1 What Canva is

Canva is an online design tool that runs in a web browser and also as a phone app. You drag and drop text, images, shapes and templates onto a page, and then download or share the result. It is built for people who are not professional designers, which makes it an ideal starting point for this course.

Canva is used for far more than posters. People make presentations, resumes, websites, videos, documents, whiteboards for meetings, social media calendars and printed products. Many professional designers also use Canva for quick client work and for creating templates.

2.2 Who uses Canva

- Small business owners who post on social media every week
- Teachers and students making worksheets and presentations
- Marketing teams that need many versions of one design
- Freelancers and agencies who deliver client work quickly
- Non-profit groups and community organisations

2.3 Canva plans

Canva offers several plans. The names and prices change, so check **canva.com/pricing** before you decide. In general:

Plan	Who it suits	What it generally adds
Free	Learning, personal projects, first practice	Large library of templates, basic photos and elements, core editing tools
Pro (paid)	Freelancers and anyone doing paid work	Premium templates, photos and fonts, Brand Kit, Background Remover, resizing with Magic Switch, Bulk Create and more AI features, larger storage
Teams (paid)	Small teams sharing one brand	Shared brand folders, team roles, collaboration controls
Enterprise (paid)	Large organisations	Advanced security, administration and support
Education and Non-profit	Eligible schools and charities	Pro-level features free or at a discount, if you qualify

Tip. Start on the Free plan. Upgrade to Pro only when a paid client needs premium content or the Brand Kit, and when you can see the time it saves you. Canva often offers a free trial of Pro; note the date you start it and cancel before it ends if you are not ready to pay.

Careful: licences. Many Canva photos, templates and fonts are licensed for use in your own designs, with limits. Free and Pro content differ in what you may use commercially. Read the Canva Content Licence on canva.com before you sell a design that contains Canva elements. Chapter 13 explains this further.

2.4 Canva compared with professional software

Canva is quick and easy. Professional tools such as Adobe Photoshop and Illustrator offer far more control, especially for photo retouching and logo vector work. The table below helps you decide when each is the right choice.

Task	Canva is good for	Use a professional tool when
Social posts, flyers, menus	Most of the time	The client wants very complex photo edits
Presentations	Almost always	Data charts need precise engineering
Logos	Simple wordmarks and drafts	Trademark-quality, scalable vector logos
Photo retouching	Basic fixes, background removal	Portrait retouching or colour grading
Video	Short social clips	Long-form editing or film-quality work

2.5 The home screen

When you sign in, the home screen is your starting point. The layout below is a simplified schematic; menu labels may differ slightly in your version.

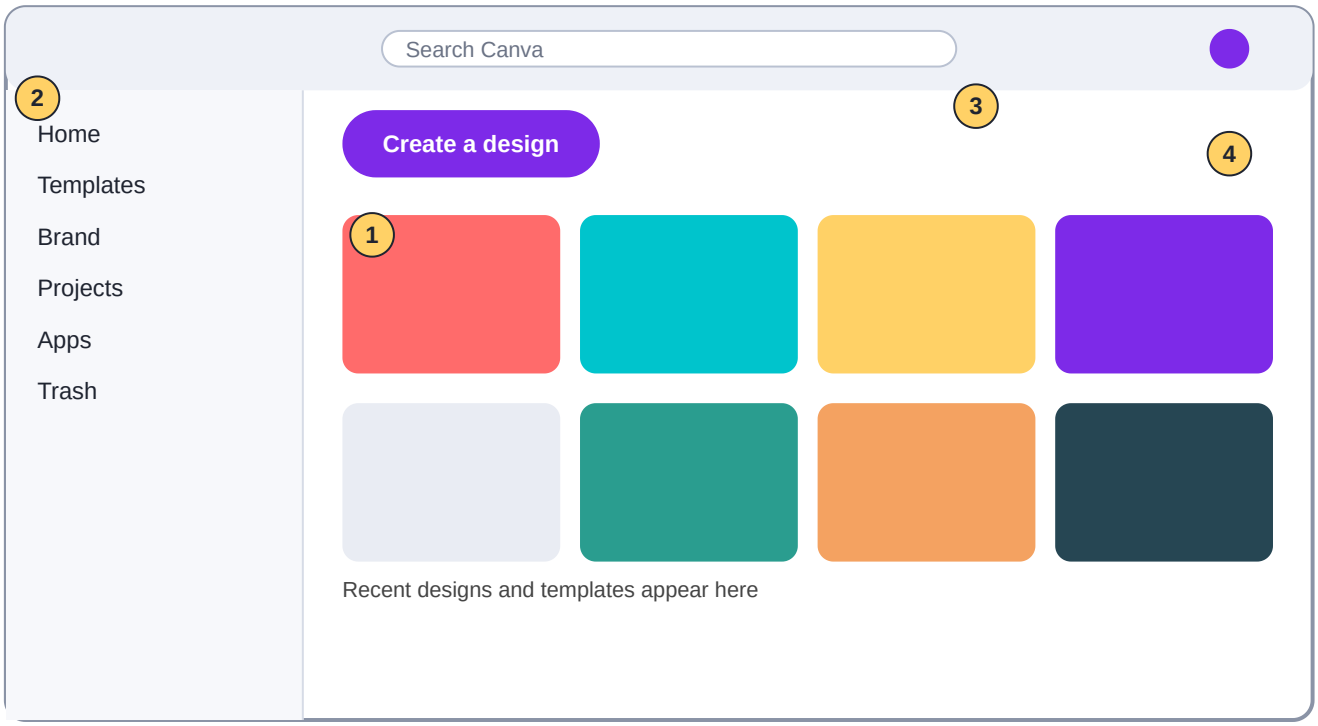


*Figure 2.1 Home screen schematic. **1** Create a design (start a new project). **2** Main menu. **3** Search for templates, elements and help. **4** Your account and profile.*

The left column holds the main menu. "Templates" shows ready-made designs, "Brand" appears on paid plans and holds your logos, colours and fonts, and "Projects" lists everything you have made. Your recent designs appear in the main area.

> **Exercise 2.** Sign in (or sign up, as in Chapter 3). Click through every item in the left menu, then write a list of five things you saw. Note which items require a paid plan; a small lock or "Pro" badge usually shows this.

CHAPTER 3

Creating Your Canva Account

This chapter walks you through creating a secure, professional account. You will need about 20 minutes and access to the email address you want to use for work.

3.1 Before you start

- **An email address for work.** Use a plain name such as *firstname.lastname@* your email provider. Do not use a joke address; clients will see it.
- **A password manager** (the one built into your browser is fine) to create and store a long, unique password.
- **Your phone**, in case you need to confirm your identity by text message or an authenticator app.
- **A decision on account type.** Canva asks what you will use it for. Choose the option that matches your goal, such as personal or business use. You can change later.

3.2 Step-by-step sign-up

1. Open a browser and go to **canva.com**. Click **Sign up** (or "Get started").
2. Choose how to sign up. You can use **Google**, **Apple**, another single sign-on option, or your **email address**. If you choose email, Canva will send a confirmation code or link.
3. If you use email, enter your name, email and a password. Use at least 12 characters with a mix of words, numbers and symbols, or a generated password from your password manager.
4. Confirm your email. Open the message from Canva and click the verification link or enter the code.
5. Answer the short questions (for example, your role and what you plan to design). These help Canva suggest templates. Answer honestly; you can skip some questions.
6. Canva may offer a Pro trial and ask for payment details. **You do not need to enter a card to use the Free plan.** Choose "Continue with free" or the equivalent if you are still learning.
7. You land on the home screen. Take a moment to note where the menu, search and account icon are (see Chapter 2).

> **Careful.** Only type card details into canva.com itself, never into a link or message that someone sent you. A message that says "your account will be closed unless you pay now" is almost always a scam.

3.3 Set up your profile

Click your account icon in the top-right corner and open **Settings** (or "Account settings"). Check these items:

Setting	What to enter	Why it matters
Name	Your real first and last name, or your professional name	Clients recognise you; collaborators can find you
Profile photo	A clear, friendly head-and-shoulders photo	Builds trust when you share links with clients
Language and region	English, and your country	Sets currency, spelling and some template suggestions
Email preferences	Keep product updates on, marketing off if you wish	Reduces clutter while keeping important notices

3.4 Turn on two-step verification

Protecting your account matters because it may hold client designs and, later, payment information. In the settings, look for **Security** and turn on **two-step verification** (sometimes called two-factor authentication). Choose the method you prefer, such as an authenticator app or a text message. Save the backup codes Canva gives you in your password manager.

> **Tip.** Also turn on two-step verification on the email account you used to sign up. If someone gets into your email, they can reset your Canva password.

3.5 Account types you may meet

- **Personal account:** one user, one set of designs. Enough for learning and first freelance jobs.
- **Team account:** several people share brand assets and folders. You will need this if you hire an assistant or work in a small agency.
- **Education or non-profit:** available if you are a teacher, student or registered charity. Requirements change, so check the official page before you apply.

3.6 Common sign-up problems

Problem	What to do
The confirmation email does not arrive	Check spam and promotions folders. Wait five minutes, then request a new email.
"Account already exists"	You may have signed up with Google or Apple before. Use that button instead of email, or use "Forgot password".
Verification code expired	Request a new code. Codes expire after a short time.
Page keeps asking you to upgrade	Close the pop-up and continue on the free plan. Ignore pressure tactics.
Cannot sign in on a new device	Use your password manager, or your two-step verification method and backup codes.

> **Exercise 3.** Create your account, enable two-step verification, and write your account email and the date you created it in your notebook (not in a shared file). Then sign out and sign back in to confirm it works.

CHAPTER 4

Walking Through the Canva Editor

Designing in Canva happens in the *editor*: the screen where you change a design. This chapter explains each area and the everyday actions you will repeat thousands of times.

4.1 Starting a design

There are three common ways to begin:

- **Use a preset size** from the list (for example Instagram Post, A4 Document, Presentation). Canva sets the correct pixel size.
- **Use a custom size** when a client gives you measurements. Enter width and height in pixels, or in millimetres or inches for print.
- **Start from a template.** Pick a design, then replace the text and images. This is the fastest way to learn layout.

4.2 The editor layout

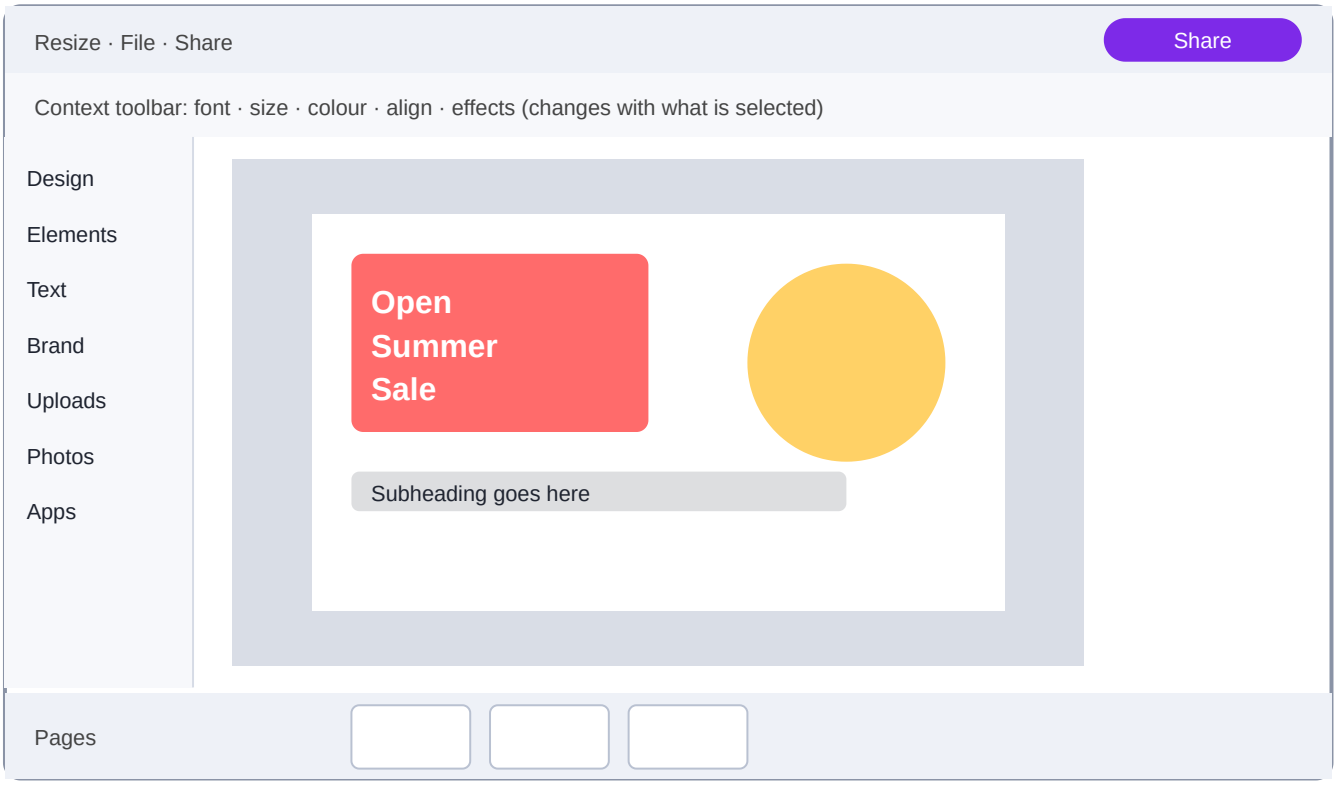


Figure 4.1 The editor. Top bar: file, resize and share. Context toolbar: options for the selected item. Left panel: tools (Design, Elements, Text, Brand, Uploads, Photos, Apps). Centre: the canvas you design on. Bottom: page thumbnails.

The five areas you will use most are:

1. **Top bar:** file name, undo and redo, resize, download and share.
2. **Context toolbar:** changes depending on what you have selected. Select a text box and you see font and size controls; select a photo and you see crop and filter controls.
3. **Left panel:** where you find templates, elements (shapes, lines, icons), text styles, your brand assets and your uploaded files.

4. **Canvas:** the page itself. Click an item to select it, drag to move, use corner handles to resize.
5. **Page bar:** the thumbnails at the bottom. Use this for multi-page documents and presentations.

4.3 Working with text

Click **Text** in the left panel and choose a heading, subheading or body style, or click the plus-sign to add a text box. Double-click text on the canvas to edit it. Use the context toolbar to change font, size, colour, line spacing and alignment.

> **Tip.** Create your own text styles once (headline, subheading, body) and reuse them. Consistent text styles make your work look professional across a whole project.

4.4 Images, shapes and elements

- **Elements** include shapes, lines, frames, icons and illustrations. Search by keyword, for example "coffee icon".
- **Photos** are stock images. Check the licence label and whether the photo is marked for Pro users.
- **Uploads** hold your own files. Upload logos, product photos and client images here, not from random websites.
- **Frames** let you place a photo inside a shape. Drag a photo onto a frame, or use the crop tool.

4.5 Layers, arrangement and grouping

Items stack on top of each other. To move something behind another item, select it and use the **Position** menu (often in the context toolbar) to bring it forward or send it back. To move several items together, select them with a drag box or with Shift-click, then **Group** them. Use **Lock** on a background so it cannot be moved by accident.

4.6 Pages, duplicating and undo

- **Add a page** with the plus-sign in the page bar, or duplicate a page with the copy icon.
- **Duplicate an item** with Ctrl+D on Windows or Cmd+D on Mac.
- **Undo** with Ctrl+Z or Cmd+Z. Redo with Ctrl+Shift+Z or Cmd+Shift+Z.
- **Rename the design** by clicking the file name at the top. Use dated names.

4.7 Saving, downloading and sharing

Canva saves automatically as you work. Check the file name and the "saved" indicator if you are unsure. To get a finished file, click **Share** and then **Download**. Choose the file type that matches the use:

File type	Best for
PNG	Social posts, graphics with transparency, sharp text on screen
JPG	Photos and smaller web images where file size matters
PDF Standard	Sharing documents for screen reading, emailing a proposal
PDF Print	Printing at a shop; ask the printer whether they need bleed or crop marks
MP4 / GIF	Animated designs and short videos
PPTX	When a client wants to edit a presentation in PowerPoint

Careful. Before you send a design to a printer, check the size, the colours and the resolution with the printer. Screens show colour as RGB; printers usually use CMYK, so bright screen colours can print duller.

Exercise 4. Create a 1080 × 1080 px design. Add a background colour, a headline, one shape, and one photo or icon. Group the shape and the icon, lock the background, duplicate the design, change the text on the copy, and download it as a PNG. Name the file with today's date.

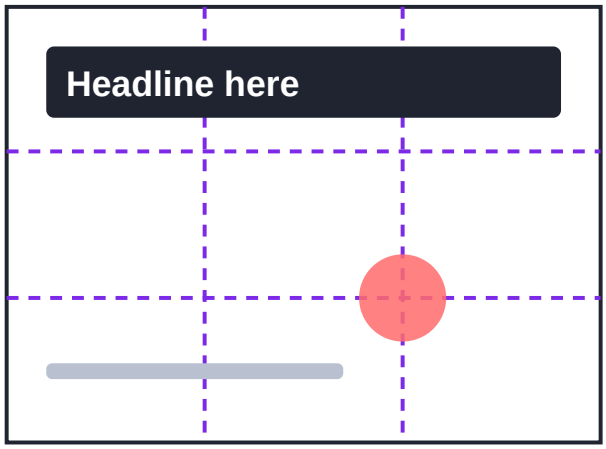
CHAPTER 5

Design Fundamentals You Can Apply in Canva

Canva makes it easy to place things on a page. Good design is about *why* things are placed where they are. This chapter teaches the principles behind professional-looking work. Each principle can be applied with Canva's tools right away.

5.1 Layout and the grid

A grid is an invisible structure that keeps items lined up. The simplest guide is the **rule of thirds**: divide the page into three columns and three rows. Place important things, such as a headline or a focal point, on the lines or where they cross. Canva shows helpful guides when you drag items near the edges and centre of the page.



Rule of thirds

The purple lines divide the page into nine equal parts. The red dot sits on an intersection, a stronger position than dead centre.

Headlines usually sit on the top third line, and the main image or subject on one of the lower intersections.

Figure 5.1 The rule of thirds. Place the focal point on or near an intersection.

5.2 Four principles every layout follows

Principle	Meaning	Practical step in Canva
Alignment	Everything lines up with something else	Use the guides; align left edges of text blocks; use Align from the toolbar
Proximity	Related items sit close; unrelated items are apart	Put a title and its subtitle close together; leave wide gaps between sections
Repetition	Use the same colours, fonts and shapes throughout	Save your colours in Brand Kit or a palette; reuse text styles
Contrast	Make important things clearly different	Use bold headlines and light body text, or a dark background with light text

5.3 Typography: fonts and hierarchy

Typography is the art of arranging text. Most beginner mistakes come from using too many fonts, too many sizes, or text that is too small. Use this rule: **one or two font families per design**, with clear size steps between levels.

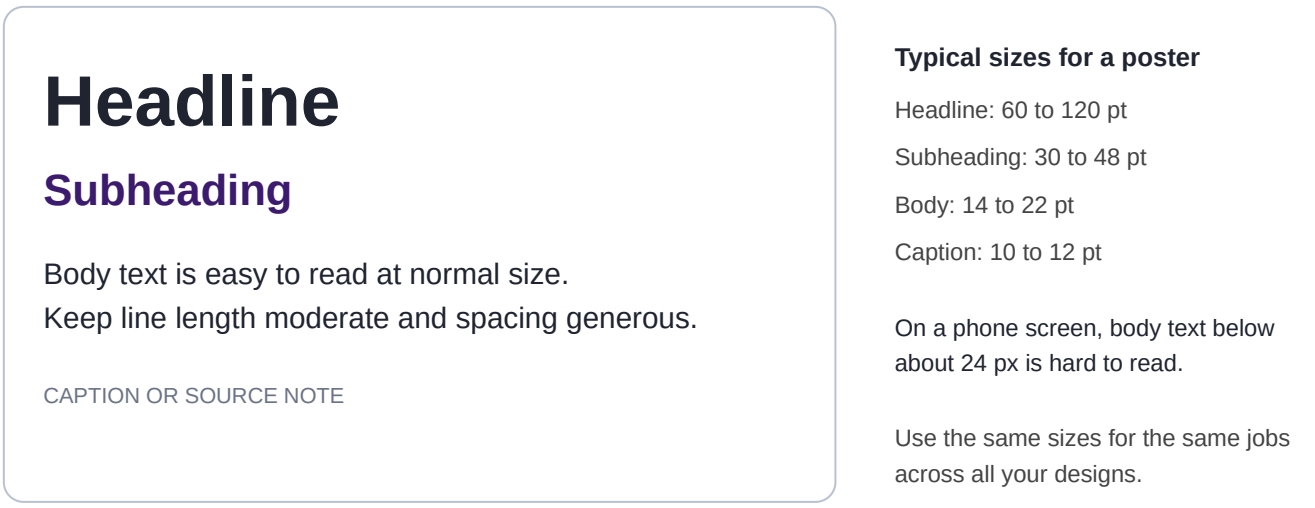


Figure 5.2 Visual hierarchy. Each level is clearly larger or heavier than the one below it.

5.4 Font pairing and readability

- Pair a bold, friendly display font for headlines with a simple, clean font for body text.
- Avoid decorative script fonts for long sentences.
- Do not mix more than three fonts. Two is usually enough.
- Give lines room: line spacing of about 1.3 to 1.5 times the font size keeps body text comfortable.
- Use Canva's font filter to show only fonts that are free for commercial use if you plan to sell designs. Check the licence of each font.

5.5 Colour: palettes and contrast

Colour sets mood and draws attention. A simple way to choose a palette is the colour wheel. Three classic schemes are shown below.

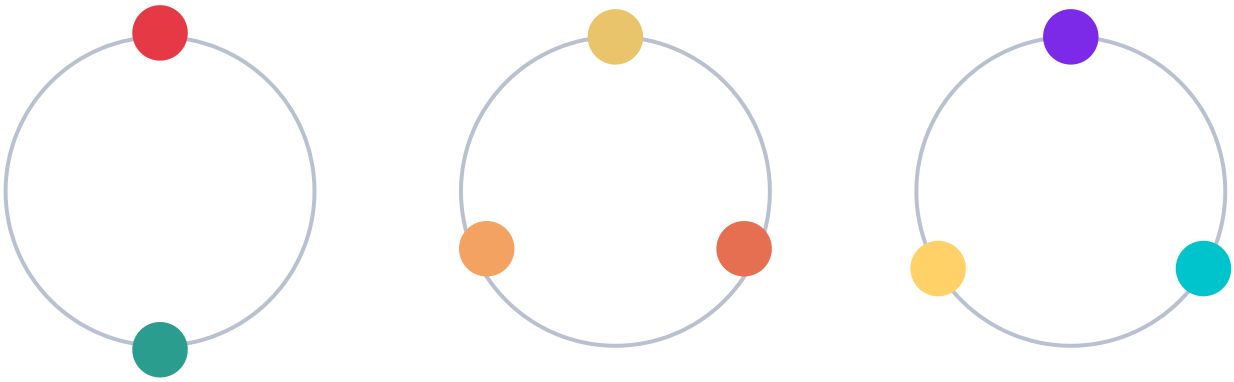


Figure 5.3 Three colour schemes. Start with one main colour, one support colour, and a neutral (white, off-white or dark grey) for text and space.

Contrast decides whether text can be read. For body text, aim for a contrast ratio of at least **4.5 to 1** between text and background (this is the common accessibility guideline known as WCAG AA). Dark grey on white or white on deep blue usually passes. Light grey on white usually fails. Canva's colour pickers sometimes show the contrast; if not, use a free online contrast checker.

5.6 Imagery and white space

- **Use strong images.** One clear, relevant photo beats three weak ones.
- **Keep the subject visible.** Do not place text over a person's face.
- **Leave white space (negative space).** Empty areas let the eye rest and make the important items stand out. Beginners usually fill too much space; remove one element and see whether the design improves.

5.7 Accessibility checklist

Accessible design helps everyone, including people with low vision, colour blindness or older screens. Before you deliver any design, check:

- Body text is at least about 14 pt in print or about 24 px on a phone-sized social post.
- Contrast is strong enough for text (see 5.5).
- Colour is not the only way to show meaning; add labels or icons too.
- Important information is not written only inside a tiny image.
- Social posts that contain text also include a caption that repeats the key information, for screen-reader users.

> **Exercise 5.** Find a poorly designed flyer or post (your own is fine). Write down three things wrong with it, using the four principles in 5.2. Then rebuild it in Canva with a clear headline, one palette of three colours and at most two fonts. Compare the two versions side by side and note which one you would hire.

CHAPTER 6

Hands-On Projects

Theory becomes skill only when you make things. Each project below follows the same pattern: **brief, specification, steps, quality check**. Work through them in order. Save every finished file in a folder called *Practice*; these will feed your portfolio in Chapter 8.

> **Tip.** Before you start any project, write a one-line brief: "Who is this for, what should they do after seeing it, and what must be included?" A clear brief makes every decision easier.

Project 1: Instagram square post (1080 × 1080 px)

Brief: A bakery announces a new seasonal product.

1. Click **Create a design** and choose **Instagram Post**.
2. Set a background colour from your palette. Add a large headline such as "New: Mango Cake". Keep it under six words.
3. Add one product photo or icon. Place it on a rule-of-thirds intersection.
4. Add a short line of supporting text and a call to action, for example "Order today".
5. Check alignment with the guides; check the text is readable on a phone.
6. Download as PNG.

Quality check: Can you read the headline in one second? Is there one clear focus? Are colours and fonts consistent with your other practice pieces?

Project 2: Social media set (three sizes)

Clients often need the same message in several formats. Canva's **Magic Switch** (Chapter 7) can do this for you, but first learn the sizes manually.

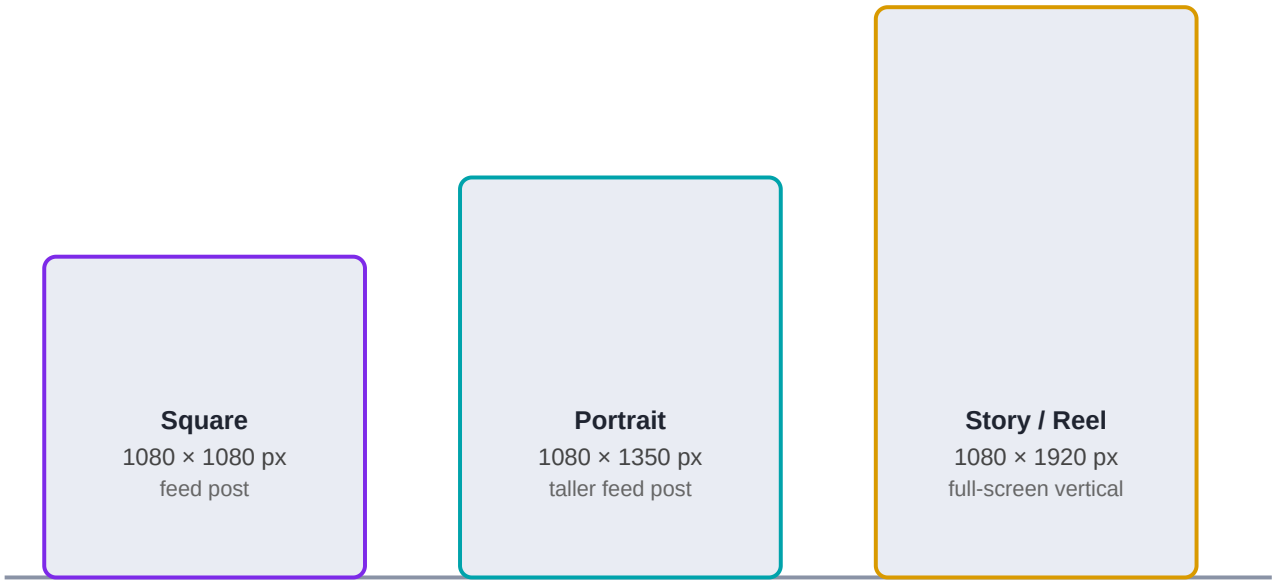


Figure 6.1 Common social media sizes drawn to the same scale. The vertical story needs the most space at the top and bottom for captions and buttons; keep key text in the middle.

Steps: Build the square design first. Duplicate it, change the size to Portrait, and adjust the layout. Then duplicate again for Story. Keep text at least about 250 px away from the top and bottom edges of the story so the app's own buttons do not cover it.

> **Careful.** Platforms change their recommended sizes. Check the current guidance on each platform before you deliver to a client.

Project 3: A5 flyer for an event

Brief: A community library runs a free reading day on a Saturday.

1. Create a **Custom size** of A5 (148 × 210 mm) or choose A5 from the presets.
2. Place the event title at the top third. Use the largest text on the page.
3. Add three essential details only: date and time, place, and what visitors get.
4. Add a QR code or a website as the call to action. (Canva Apps include QR code tools; check licensing if you use a third-party generator.)
5. Use a large photo or simple illustration in the lower half, and leave a clear margin around all text.
6. Download as **PDF Print**. Ask a printer whether they want bleed (extra colour past the trim edge), usually 3 mm. Chapter 4 explains print files.

Project 4: Professional resume (CV)

Brief: A job seeker wants a one- or two-page resume for an office role.

1. Search templates for "resume" and choose a clean, single-column design. Avoid heavy graphics and multiple columns, because some applicant tracking systems read them badly.
2. Replace the sample text with real content, in this order: name and contact, short profile (two to three lines), experience (newest first), education, skills, and languages.
3. Use action verbs and numbers: "Reduced invoice errors by 30 percent" is clearer than "Responsible for invoices".
4. Keep the font size readable (about 10 to 11 pt for body) and margins of about 15 mm.
5. Download as PDF Standard. Save the file with your name, for example *Ayesha-Khan-Resume-2026.pdf*.

> **Tip.** Make a plain-text version as well, in case an online form cannot accept your design. Copy the content into a simple .txt file.

Project 5: Five-slide presentation

Brief: A small cafe owner presents a plan to open a second branch.

1. Plan the slides on paper first: title, problem, solution, numbers, call to action.
2. Choose a presentation template, then remove unnecessary elements. Use one idea per slide.
3. Use charts from the Elements panel for simple numbers. Label each axis and state the source.
4. Keep text to about six lines per slide. Put detailed notes in the presenter notes.
5. Present in full-screen mode to check the timing, then download as PDF or PPTX depending on what the client needs.

Project 6: Simple wordmark logo

Brief: A new home-baking business needs a name logo for a sticker and an Instagram profile picture.

1. Type the business name. Choose one bold or distinctive font. Canva's font library includes many logo-friendly options; check each licence.
2. Choose one colour, or two at most. Test the logo in black on white, and in white on the brand colour.
3. Make a circular or square version for the profile picture. Keep the name readable at small size.
4. Export as PNG with a transparent background, and as SVG if your plan allows.

Careful: trademarks. Before you deliver a logo, search the name in the official trademark databases of the country where the client operates, and in an internet search. A name that is already registered can cause legal trouble for your client, and possibly for you.

Project 7: Restaurant menu

Brief: A small restaurant wants a printed A4 menu with five sections.

1. Set up a grid: two columns, equal spacing, consistent item format (name in bold, description in regular, price aligned to the right).
2. Group items by section (starters, mains, desserts, drinks). Use a clear heading for each.
3. Keep prices in a consistent currency format and aligned in one column.
4. Proof-read every item twice. Spelling mistakes in a menu are costly for the client.
5. Download as PDF Print for the printer, and PDF Standard for emailing.

Practice checklist

Before you call a design finished	Done
The brief is met: the right message reaches the right audience	☐
One clear focal point; no more than two or three main messages	☐
Text is spelt correctly and checked by a second person	☐
Alignment matches the guides; spacing is consistent	☐
Colours and fonts are limited to your palette and two fonts	☐
Correct size and file type for the destination	☐
All images and fonts are licensed for this use	☐

Exercise 6. Complete Projects 1 and 4 this week. Show both to one person who is not in your family, ask them to tell you the main message after five seconds, and note what they said.

CHAPTER 7

Advanced Canva and Magic Studio

Once you can build a basic design, Canva's advanced features help you work faster and deliver more to clients. Some are available only on paid plans. Names and locations of tools change over time, so use the search box in the editor to find them if the menu differs.

7.1 Brand Kit

The Brand Kit stores a client's logo, colour palette, and fonts in one place. Once set up, every new design can use these assets with a single click. This is the single most valuable feature for client work.

1. Open **Brand** from the left menu, or from the Brand Kit section of the settings.
2. Upload the logo in a clean format (PNG with transparent background, or SVG).
3. Add the brand colours using their exact codes (HEX values such as #7D2AE8). Ask the client for these codes rather than guessing from a screenshot.
4. Add the brand fonts. You may need the client's font files, or permission to use fonts Canva already provides.

> **Tip.** Create a separate Brand Kit for each client. Keep your own brand as one kit, and name each kit clearly. Mixing clients' assets is a common and embarrassing mistake.

7.2 Magic Studio tools

Magic Studio is Canva's set of AI-assisted tools. The names and availability change, so treat this list as a guide:

Tool (as named in 2026)	What it helps with	Your check
Magic Design	Creates design ideas from a text prompt or your photos	Replace generic text; make sure the look fits the brand
Magic Write	Drafts or rewrites short copy	Verify facts, prices and claims yourself
Magic Media	Generates images or video from text	Check for odd details, copyright risk and the client's rules before use
Magic Edit	Changes part of an image by describing the change	Look closely at edges and hands or faces
Background Remover	Removes the background from a photo	Check hair, edges and small objects
Magic Switch	Converts a design to another format or size	Re-check text placement and crop

> **Careful.** AI output can be wrong, can copy styles too closely, and may not be fully free of third-party rights. Read Canva's terms for AI features, tell clients when AI was used if their contract or their industry requires it, and never let AI write medical, legal or financial claims without a qualified person checking them.

7.3 Bulk Create

Bulk Create (a Pro feature) produces many versions of one design from a spreadsheet. Example: 50 name badges for an event, or 30 product cards with different names and prices. You prepare a CSV file with one row per item, link each column to a text or image spot in your design, and Canva generates a file for each row.

1. Design one master page with placeholder text such as "{Name}".
2. Prepare a spreadsheet with a header row and one row per item. Keep it simple: no merged cells.
3. Upload the spreadsheet and map each column to a text box.
4. Preview several rows before generating all of them.

7.4 Animation and short video

Canva lets you animate elements (fade, slide, pop) and create short videos. For social media, keep videos under about 15 seconds for the first attempt, with large text and a clear message in the first two seconds. Use the **Animate** button in the context toolbar and preview with the play button in the timeline. Add background music only from licensed sources, and check whether the platform you publish to requires a separate music licence.

7.5 Canva Websites and Docs

Canva also offers simple website builders and document editors. For a beginner freelancer these are good for a one-page portfolio or a proposal. A professional web host or a dedicated portfolio platform (Chapter 8) may be better for a long-term site, especially if you need a custom domain and search-engine control.

7.6 Collaboration and feedback

- **Share** a design with a link, with edit or view permission. Use view-only links for drafts you want clients to comment on.
- **Comments** let a client point to an item and ask for a change. Keep a written record of every requested change.
- **Versions:** duplicate a design before major changes, and name the copies "v1", "v2", so you can roll back.

7.7 Building a reusable template system

Good freelancers rarely start from zero. Build a folder of master templates for your most common jobs (social post, flyer, menu, presentation). Each one uses your palette and fonts. When a new client arrives, duplicate a master, load their Brand Kit and change the content. This is how you deliver quickly without sacrificing quality.

> **Exercise 7.** Create a free Brand Kit (or use the Brand features in your trial) for a fictional business of your choice. Give it a logo, three colours and two fonts. Build a social post and a flyer that use only those assets, then duplicate the post as a master template named "MASTER – Social Post".

CHAPTER 8

Building a Portfolio and Personal Brand

A portfolio is your proof of skill. Clients rarely hire a designer on a list of software skills alone; they want to see examples that look like what they need. A focused, honest portfolio of eight strong pieces beats fifty weak ones.

8.1 What clients look for

- **Relevance:** examples that match the work they want (for example, restaurant menus for a restaurant client).
- **Clarity:** you explain the problem and your solution in a few sentences.
- **Reliability:** a professional profile, quick replies, and clean, error-free work.
- **Proof of results:** numbers, feedback or testimonials, where possible.

8.2 Choose and structure your projects

Select 6 to 8 pieces from your Practice folder (Chapter 6) and any real work you have done. Use the **case study** format for each one:

Part	What to write (two to four sentences)
The problem	What the client needed, and why it mattered
Your approach	Key decisions: audience, palette, layout, message
The output	The design(s), shown clearly
The result	Feedback, sales, engagement, or "practice project, client to be confirmed"

Be honest. If a project was a practice exercise, label it as one. Never claim a result you cannot support. Never show a client's confidential material without their permission.

8.3 Portfolio structure

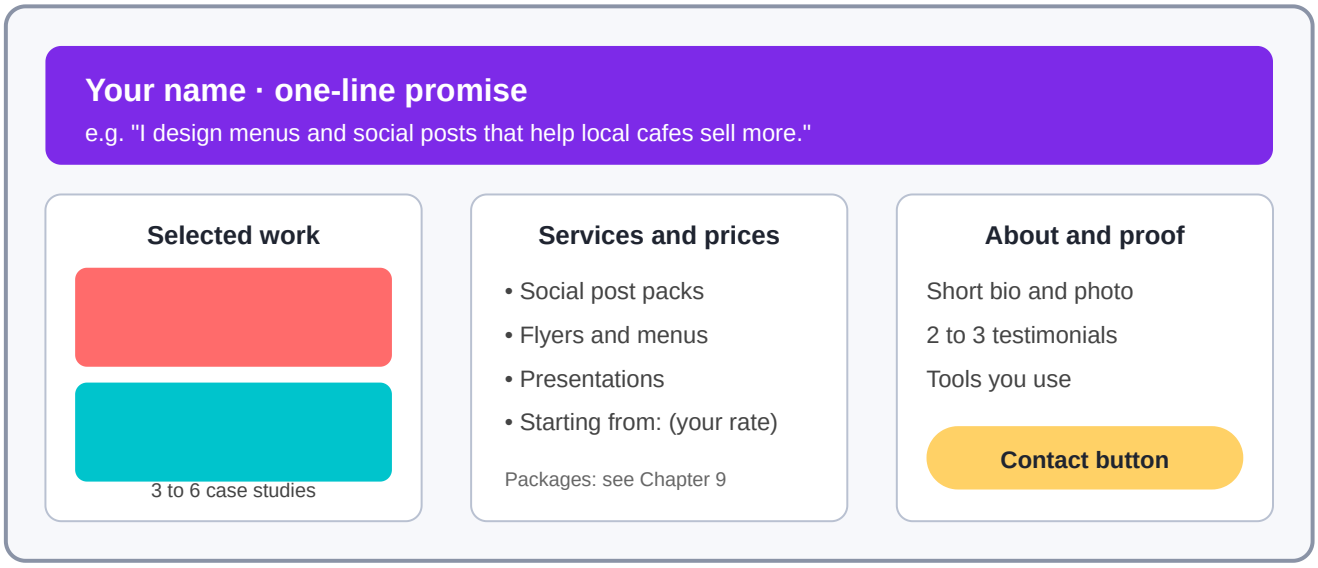


Figure 8.1 A one-page portfolio: promise, selected work, services, proof, and an easy way to contact you.

8.4 Where to publish

Option	Good for	Notes
Canva website or a published design	A quick one-page portfolio	Fastest start; check features and branding on your plan
Behance	Creative case studies with images	Owned by Adobe; free to join; strong for graphic and branding work
Dribbble	Short shots and UI work	Invitation or application process for some features; popular with digital designers
Personal site	Full control, custom domain	Needs a domain (a yearly cost) and some setup; a simple site builder helps
PDF portfolio	Sending to clients by email	Keep it under about 10 MB so it opens on phones

Tip. Keep a PDF version of your portfolio at all times. Many clients will ask for one, and some will not click a link from an unknown sender.

8.5 Personal brand basics

- **Choose a niche** when you are ready, such as "menus and posters for cafes" or "resumes for nurses". A niche makes marketing easier. You can start broad and narrow later.
- **Create a simple identity:** a name or a clear professional title, a profile photo, one colour palette, and one font pair. Use them on your portfolio, your social profiles and your invoices.
- **Write a bio of 50 to 80 words:** who you help, what you make, and how you work. Replace it as your skills grow.
- **Be consistent.** Use the same name and photo on every platform so clients recognise you.

8.6 Creating samples when you have no clients

Beginners often say, "I have no work to show." Solve this with *spec work for practice*. Pick a real local business (a cafe, a clinic, a tutor) and create a redesign or sample campaign for it. Label it clearly as an unsolicited concept, for example "Concept redesign for a local cafe, not commissioned". Do not imply that the business hired you. You may later contact them with the concept; many small businesses respond well to a free sample.

Careful. Do not use another designer's work, or a business's logo, as if it were yours. Do not copy a competitor's layout so closely that it could be confused with theirs. Original concepts are safer and better for your reputation.

Exercise 8. Write a 60-word bio, choose six Practice pieces, and write a case study of 80 words for the best one. Build a one-page PDF portfolio in Canva using the structure in Figure 8.1.

CHAPTER 9

Pricing, Finding Clients and Communicating

Pricing and client communication cause most early stress for freelancers. This chapter gives you a method you can adapt to your country, your skills and the market, rather than fixed numbers that would soon be out of date.

9.1 Pricing models

Model	How it works	Best for	Risk
Hourly	You charge per hour worked	Unclear or open-ended tasks	Clients may question time; you earn less as you get faster
Per project (fixed)	One price for an agreed scope	Defined jobs like a flyer or menu	Scope creep if the brief is vague
Per deliverable	A price per item (per post, per slide)	Social media packs, templates	Clients may ask for many small extras
Retainer	A monthly fee for an agreed amount of work	Clients who need ongoing content	Needs firm limits on revisions and turnaround

9.2 A simple method to set your rate

Work backwards from the income you need:

1. **Monthly income goal** (after tax): for example, 1,000 units of your currency.
2. **Add business costs** per month: software, internet, phone, portfolio hosting. Example: 100.
3. **Total needed:** 1,100.
4. **Billable hours:** not every hour of your week is paid, because sales, admin and learning take time too. In your first year, a realistic target is about 50 billable hours a month, even if you work more hours overall.
5. **Hourly rate needed** = 1,100 ÷ 50 = 22 per billable hour.

This is a starting calculation, not a final price. Check what similar freelancers charge in your market. Then price by value: a menu that helps a restaurant sell more is worth more to the owner than the hours it took you to design it.

> **Tip.** Increase your rate for every new client, or every three months. Raise prices for new clients first; existing clients usually get notice of 30 days or a clear change at renewal.

9.3 Package tiers

Offer three packages. Clients tend to choose the middle one when it is clearly the best value. Example for social media:

	Basic	Standard (most popular)	Premium
Posts per month	8	12	20
Stories or covers	None	4	8
Revisions	1 round	2 rounds	3 rounds

Turnaround	5 working days	3 working days	2 working days
Price	Your base price	About 1.5 times base	About 2.5 times base

Change the numbers to suit your workload. The point is that every package has a clear limit, so you are never working for free.

9.4 Finding your first clients

1. **Your network first.** Tell friends, family, former colleagues and teachers what you can do, and ask them to name one business that might need it. Warm introductions convert best.
2. **Local businesses.** Walk into or message shops, clinics and cafes with a sample. Offer a fixed small service at a starter price for the first job.
3. **Online profiles.** Post your portfolio on LinkedIn and Instagram. Share one piece of design advice per week, and show your process.
4. **Platforms.** Marketplaces (Chapter 10) bring leads, although they take a fee and are competitive.
5. **Referrals.** After a good job, ask for a short testimonial and an introduction.

9.5 A simple outreach message

> *Hello [Name], I am [Your name], a graphic designer who makes menus and social posts for local food businesses. I noticed your cafe's Instagram has great photos but the posts do not show your daily specials clearly. I have made a free sample post for you, attached. If it helps, I can create a set of five posts for next month at a fixed price. Would you like to see more?*

Keep outreach short, specific and polite. Mention one thing you noticed about their business, offer something useful first, and make the next step simple. Do not send the same message to hundreds of people; that is spam and it damages your reputation.

9.6 Discovery questions and the brief

Before you quote, ask:

- What is the goal of this design? (For example: more bookings, more followers, a clear announcement.)
- Who is the audience, and where will they see it?
- What must be included? What must be avoided?
- Do you have a logo, colours, fonts or brand rules?
- When do you need it, and who approves it?
- What is your budget?

9.7 Writing a proposal

A proposal confirms the work in writing. Include: your understanding of the goal; deliverables with sizes and formats; the number of revisions; timeline; price and payment terms; what is not included; and an acceptance line the client signs or replies "yes" to. Keep it to one or two pages.

9.8 Revisions and difficult conversations

Revisions are normal, but they must have limits. A common approach: "This package includes two rounds of revisions. Each round means one consolidated list of changes sent in one message. Additional changes are charged at [rate]." When a client asks for something outside scope, respond politely: "That is a good idea. It is outside the current scope, so I can add it for [price] or in the next package."

> **Careful.** Never begin large work without a deposit. A typical arrangement is 30 to 50 percent upfront for a new client, with the rest on delivery. Clients who refuse any deposit on a first project are a risk.

9.9 Worked example

A cafe asks for "some posts for our Instagram". You reply with questions, then offer a Basic package of 8 posts for a fixed monthly fee, with two rounds of revisions and a 50 percent deposit. The cafe chooses Standard instead, because it includes stories for daily specials. You send a proposal, the client signs, you invoice the deposit, and you begin. At the end of the month you ask for a testimonial and a referral.

> **Exercise 9.** Use the method in 9.2 to calculate your own minimum hourly rate. Then write a three-tier package for the service you chose in Exercise 1. Send one outreach message to a real business you know (only after you have made a sample, and only if you are comfortable with it).

CHAPTER 10

Freelance Marketplaces

Marketplaces are websites where buyers and freelancers meet. They can provide a steady flow of first clients, a payment system and a review history. They also take a fee and are very competitive. This chapter explains how to use them well and safely.

10.1 The main platforms

Platform	How it works	Good for	Notes
Fiverr	You list fixed-price "gigs" with packages; buyers order directly	Clear, small, repeatable services	Fees apply to sellers; many competitors; build reviews early
Upwork	You submit proposals to posted jobs and may pay connects or credits to bid	Longer projects and hourly contracts	Strong client verification; fees and bidding costs apply
Freelancer.com	Projects and contests; you bid on posted work	Quick projects and contests	Contests can pay little for lots of work; read terms carefully
PeoplePerHour	Offers (fixed services) and hourly jobs	UK and international clients	Fees and verification steps apply
99designs	Design contests and projects	Logos and branding for experienced designers	Contest model is competitive; a higher-skill market

Platforms change their fees, rules and features often. Check each one's current seller fee and dispute policy before you commit.

10.2 Set up a strong profile

- **Photo:** friendly and clear, with good light and no filters.
- **Headline:** say what you do and for whom, for example "Menu and social media designer for cafes and restaurants".
- **Description:** three short paragraphs: who you help, how you work, and what the client gets.
- **Skills and tools:** list Canva and the other tools you use honestly. Add the ones you have actually used.
- **Portfolio:** upload 4 to 6 of your best pieces, each with a short title.
- **Verification:** complete identity and payment verification as the platform asks. Use the same name on all platforms.

10.3 Create a gig (Fiverr-style)

1. **Title:** include your service and the outcome, for example "I will design a 5-post Instagram pack for your cafe".
2. **Packages:** offer Basic, Standard and Premium (see Chapter 9).
3. **Gallery:** use clear, relevant images and a short video if possible.
4. **Requirements:** ask buyers for what you need before starting: logo, colours, text, photos, deadline.
5. **FAQ:** answer the questions you are asked most often, such as file types and revision limits.

6. **Delivery time:** set a realistic time. Missing deadlines lowers your rating; it is better to promise three days and deliver in two.

10.4 Write winning proposals (Upwork-style)

When you bid on a job, the first two sentences matter most. Show that you read the brief. Example:

> *"Your menu needs clear sections and readable prices for a printed A4 page. I have designed three restaurant menus in Canva with this structure (samples attached). I can deliver a print-ready PDF within four working days, with two rounds of revisions."*

- Avoid copy-and-paste proposals that ignore the brief.
- Ask one or two clarifying questions. It shows care and reduces misunderstandings.
- Bid only on jobs that match your portfolio. Quality bids beat many weak ones.

10.5 Reviews, ratings and reputation

Early reviews are very valuable. To earn them: under-promise, deliver early when possible, respond to every message within a few hours, and ask for feedback politely when the work is complete. Respond to any negative review calmly and factually. Do not argue in public.

10.6 Protecting yourself from scams

Warning sign	What to do
The buyer asks you to move the conversation to WhatsApp, email or another app before hiring	Keep the conversation on the platform; that protects both sides
The buyer offers a much higher fee and asks you to pay something first	Refuse. Paying fees to receive work is a scam.
The buyer wants to send a "test" file that you must open or install	Do not open unknown files or install software from strangers
Requests for your passwords, bank PIN, or verification codes	Never share them with anyone
Payment sent to you from a fake cheque or reversed transfer	Do not release work until funds are cleared and visible in your account

> **Careful.** Keep all communication, files and payment records on the platform. If a dispute starts, the platform's record is your evidence.

10.7 A weekly routine on marketplaces

- **Monday:** review new jobs and send 3 to 5 targeted proposals or respond to enquiries.
- **Tuesday to Thursday:** deliver work, make one new piece for your portfolio or gig gallery.
- **Friday:** reply to all messages, request reviews, update your profile with your latest work, and record earnings.

Exercise 10. Create a profile on one marketplace. Write a headline, a description, and upload four portfolio pieces. Find three real jobs posted this week that match your skills, and write (but do not yet send) a proposal for each one.

CHAPTER 11

Selling Templates and Digital Products

Service work trades your time for money. Templates and digital products can earn money while you sleep, because one design can be sold many times. The trade-off is that you must build products before you see income, and marketplaces are crowded. This chapter explains the main routes and the rules you must follow.

11.1 Types of digital product

- **Editable templates:** Instagram packs, resume templates, wedding invitations, planners, menu templates. Buyers open them in Canva (or another tool) and change the text.
- **Printables:** wall art, planners, worksheets, certificates, flashcards, saved as PDF for buyers to print.
- **Graphic bundles:** sets of icons, social post frames, or brand kits you have made yourself.
- **Mini courses and guides:** a PDF or video guide on a specific skill, such as "Canva for beginners in 30 days". You may also use this course if you add substantial original material and credit the source.

11.2 Canva templates and the Canva Creators programme

Canva has run programmes that let independent creators design templates and earn when other people use them. Eligibility, the application process, the payment model and the percentage paid all change over time. Visit Canva's creator pages, read the current terms, and do not rely on any figure from a course or a video (including this one) without checking the official source first.

> **Careful.** Canva's own photos, illustrations and elements may not be sold on their own, and may not be included in a product so that a buyer could extract and reuse them separately. Build your templates from your own designs, or from assets whose licence explicitly allows this kind of use. Read the Canva Content Licence and the licence for every font and image.

11.3 Where to sell

Platform	What sells well	Notes
Etsy	Printables, editable templates, planners, wedding stationery	Large audience; follow digital-item rules; many competitors; keyword titles matter
Creative Market	Fonts, graphics, presentation and design templates	Curated marketplace; higher standards; you may need to apply
Envato Elements	Subscription library with templates and graphics	Revenue is shared by usage; a different model from selling direct
Gumroad	Your own product page with direct payment	Simple setup; you must bring your own traffic
Your own website	Full control of price and brand	Needs a payment provider and marketing work

11.4 Print-on-demand

Print-on-demand (POD) services print your designs on products such as t-shirts, mugs, posters and phone cases, and ship them when a customer orders. You do not hold stock. You upload designs, set a price, and

receive a margin on each sale. Popular POD marketplaces include Redbubble, Society6 and Teepublic, while Printful and Printify connect to your own store.

- Check each product's print area and file requirements (size, resolution, transparency).
- Order a sample of your product before you rely on the quality.
- Design for a niche: a pet, a profession, a hobby. Generic designs are very hard to sell.
- Respect trademarks. Do not use sports team names, film characters or brand logos.

11.5 Pricing and keywords

For templates, price by value and by effort. A simple Instagram pack might sell for a few dollars or the local equivalent; a full brand kit may sell for much more. Test prices and watch which listings sell. Use specific keywords in titles and tags, for example "editable Instagram template for bakery" rather than "template". Search the marketplace for the terms buyers actually use.

11.6 Quality and buyer support

- Make your template easy to use. Label editable areas and include a short instruction sheet (PDF).
- Test the template on a phone and a computer before listing.
- Include a preview image that shows the real design, not an exaggerated one.
- Answer buyer questions within a day. Many sales come from reviews.

> **Exercise 11.** Design one editable template (for example, a bakery menu or a social post pack) using your own elements and a free-to-use font. Write the listing title, description and three keywords. Do not publish until you have checked the licences.

CHAPTER 12

Similar Platforms and Transferable Skills

Canva is one tool in a large ecosystem. The principles you learn here (layout, hierarchy, colour, typography, brand consistency) work in every design tool. Learning a second tool is usually faster than learning the first, because you already understand what you are trying to do. This chapter shows how the tools relate and where each one fits a freelance career.

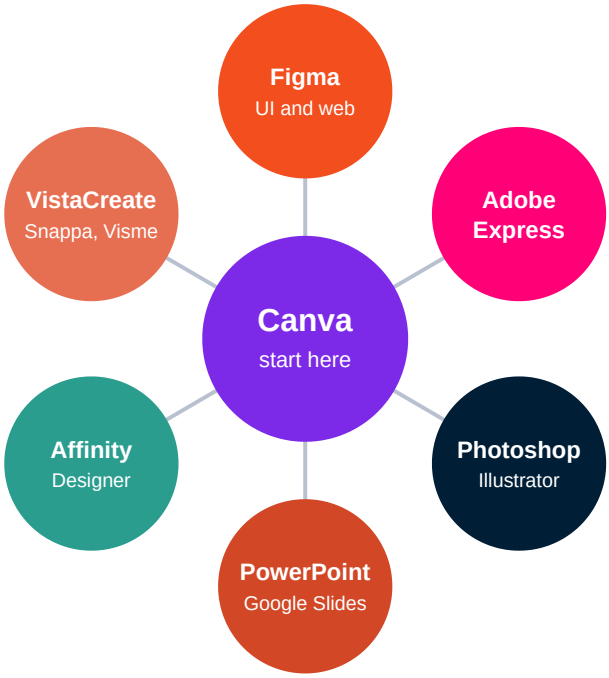


Figure 12.1 The design tool ecosystem around Canva. Lines show shared skills, not product integrations. Brand names and logos belong to their owners.

12.1 Platform comparison

Tool	Main use	Skills that transfer from Canva	Learning curve
Adobe Express	Quick social graphics and video, similar to Canva	Templates, text, brand kits, resizing	Very easy
Google Slides / PowerPoint / Keynote	Presentations, many office documents	Slide structure, hierarchy, charts	Easy
Figma	Interface (UI/UX) design, prototypes, team design systems	Layout grids, components (like reusable elements), colour styles	Moderate; very popular with product teams
Adobe Photoshop	Photo editing and retouching; pixel-based design	Layers, colour, composition	Moderate to hard
Adobe Illustrator	Vector logos, icons and print artwork	Shapes, typography, colour swatches	Moderate to hard

Affinity Designer and Affinity Photo	Vector and photo design, a professional alternative to Adobe tools	Same principles as Illustrator and Photoshop	Moderate; Affinity is now owned by Canva (check current availability and price)
VistaCreate, Snappa, Visme	Social graphics, infographics and visual reports	Templates and brand kits	Very easy
GIMP and Inkscape	Free, open-source photo and vector editing	Layers, paths, colour	Moderate; less polished interface
CapCut, DaVinci Resolve	Short-form and professional video editing	Timing, pacing, text on screen	Easy (CapCut) to hard (DaVinci)

Availability, pricing and free tiers for these tools change frequently. Confirm the current position on each vendor's website before you recommend a tool to a client.

12.2 Transferable skills, not just tools

Clients pay for thinking that works in any tool. These skills move with you:

- **Brief reading:** turning a client's words into a clear goal and a set of deliverables.
- **Visual hierarchy and layout:** the same rules apply in a poster, a slide and a web page.
- **Colour and type systems:** palettes and text styles that repeat across files.
- **File management:** versioning, naming, exporting to the right format and size.
- **Communication:** explaining choices, handling feedback, and closing projects.

12.3 A learning path for after Canva

1. **Months 1–3:** Canva for social, print and presentations. Build a portfolio.
2. **Months 4–6:** Add one tool that expands your offer. Common choices: Figma (if you are interested in apps and websites), Illustrator (if you want to design logos and icons), or CapCut (if you want to offer short videos).
3. **Months 7–12:** Learn the advanced features of your chosen tool, and offer a service that uses it. Keep Canva for speed and templates.

> **Tip.** Each new tool should earn its place. Learn it through a real or practice project, not only by watching videos. Ask yourself: "Which client need does this unlock?"

> **Exercise 12.** Take one Canva project from Chapter 6 and rebuild it in a second tool of your choice (Google Slides and Adobe Express are the easiest starting points). Write three differences you noticed in a notebook.

CHAPTER 13

Running Your Freelance Business

Important. This chapter gives general guidance. It is not legal, tax or financial advice. Tax registration, invoicing rules, contract law and payment options depend on your country. Consult a qualified accountant or lawyer in your area before you sign large contracts or register a business.

13.1 Register and get set up

- **Register as self-employed or a sole trader** with your local tax authority if the law requires it. Many countries have a simple process for individuals.
- **Choose a business name** that you are allowed to use and that is not already taken. Check trademark and company registers.
- **Open a separate bank account** for business income and expenses. It makes tax records far easier.
- **Keep your receipts** for software, equipment and internet bills. Many of these may be deductible, depending on local rules.

13.2 Getting paid

Method	Strengths	Watch for
Marketplace escrow (Fiverr, Upwork and others)	Buyer pays first; less risk of non-payment	Fees and withdrawal delays; check the rules
Bank transfer	Direct, low cost for large amounts	Confirm the account details by phone or a known channel
Online payment services (PayPal, Wise, Payoneer, others)	Works across borders; quick to set up	Currency conversion fees; availability depends on your country
Card payment links (Stripe and similar)	Professional invoices with card payments	Requires account verification and may not be available everywhere

Careful. A payment is not complete until the money is in your account and cleared. Do not start work on a payment that is "pending" or that you have only seen as a screenshot.

13.3 Invoices

Every paid job needs an invoice. Include: your name or business name and contact details; the client's name and details; an invoice number and date; a description of each service; the amount, currency and taxes (if you charge them); payment terms and due date; and your bank or payment details. Number your invoices in sequence (INV-001, INV-002) so your records stay complete.

13.4 Contracts and proposals

For any job above a small amount, use a simple written agreement. It should cover:

Clause	What it says
Scope	Exactly what you will deliver, sizes, formats and number of items

Revisions	How many rounds are included, and the process
Timeline	Start date, delivery dates and what happens if the client is late with feedback
Payment	Price, deposit, due dates and late-payment rules
Client responsibilities	Providing content, brand assets and timely approval
Ownership and licensing	Who owns the design, and how the client may use it (see 13.5)
Cancellation	How either side can end the work and what is paid for completed work
Confidentiality	How you will handle the client's private information

13.5 Copyright, licences and fonts

- **Copyright** usually belongs to the creator unless a contract transfers it. Most freelancers grant the client a licence to use the final work. Decide the scope (for example, use in one country for one year) and state it in writing.
- **Canva content:** templates, photos and elements have licences with limits. Read Canva's Content Licence and the individual licence where it applies.
- **Fonts:** check whether the font allows commercial use, embedding in print and in apps. Some fonts require a separate licence for logos.
- **Stock photos and music:** keep proof of the licence. Check whether your client's use (print run, paid ads, merchandise) is included.
- **AI-generated images:** check the platform's terms and your client's policies before using them in paid work.

13.6 Tools for running the business

Need	Simple options
Documents and proposals	Canva Docs, Google Docs, Word
Spreadsheets and tracking	Google Sheets, Excel
Scheduling and calls	Google Calendar, a booking link tool
Time tracking	A simple timer app, or a notebook
Project tracking	Trello, Notion, or a checklist in a spreadsheet
Cloud file storage	Google Drive, Dropbox, OneDrive (keep one backup copy off-site)

13.7 Time, energy and boundaries

- Set working hours and tell clients when you reply.
- Block time for admin and marketing, not only for paid work.
- Take at least one full day off each week. Burnout ends careers quickly.
- Say no to work that does not fit your skills, budget or schedule. Refer it to someone else if you can.

13.8 Records you must keep

Keep a simple monthly record: every invoice issued, every payment received (with date and platform), every business expense (with receipt), and any taxes you have set aside. Set aside a percentage of each payment for

tax as soon as it arrives; the exact amount depends on local rules and should be confirmed with an accountant.

> **Exercise 13.** Create a one-page contract template for a social media pack, and an invoice template with numbering. Ask a local accountant or business advisor to review them (many offer a short free consultation).

CHAPTER 14

Your 90-Day Roadmap, Glossary and Checklist

This final chapter turns the course into a plan. The schedule below assumes about one to two hours on most weekdays and a few hours on weekends. Adjust it to your life; consistency matters more than speed.

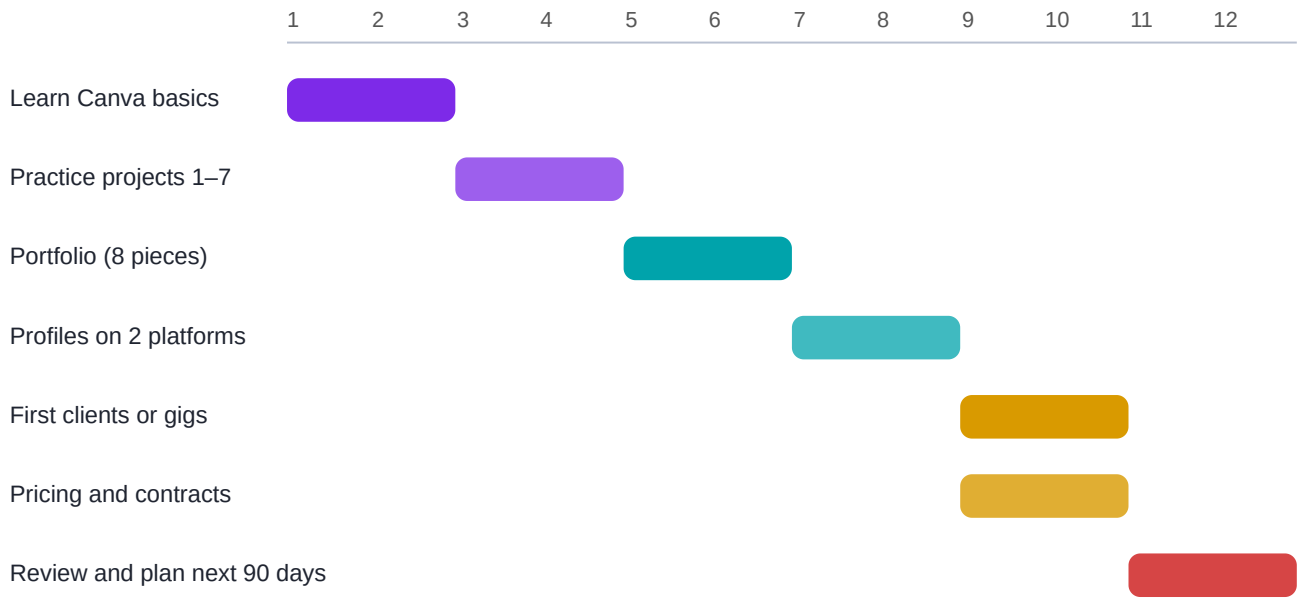


Figure 14.1 A 12-week (about 90-day) plan. Bars show when each stage is active; some stages overlap on purpose.

14.1 The plan week by week

Weeks	Focus	Outcome
1–2	Account setup, editor basics, Chapters 2–4	Account secured; Exercises 2–4 complete
3–4	Design principles and seven practice projects	Seven pieces in your Practice folder
5–6	Brand Kit, templates, portfolio build	Eight-piece portfolio as PDF and online
7–8	Profiles on two platforms; first outreach; five sample posts	Live profiles; 10 outreach messages sent
9–10	First client work or gig; pricing packages; contract template	First paid job or first order
11	Deliver, request review, improve the next job	Testimonial received; process written down
12	Review numbers; set goals for the next quarter	Written plan for the next 90 days

14.2 Learning resources

- **Canva Design School** (free, official): short courses on design basics and using Canva. Search "Canva Design School" in your browser.
- **Canva's official help centre and YouTube channel:** step-by-step guides for every feature.
- **Principles of design books and courses:** look for beginner-friendly titles on layout, typography and colour from libraries or reputable online course providers.
- **Local libraries and community colleges:** many offer low-cost or free design, computer and small business courses.

- **Feedback communities:** online design groups and local meetups where you can share work and receive honest critique.

> **Careful.** Verify any "certificate" you pay for. Free courses from official providers are often enough to start, and no certificate guarantees work.

14.3 Glossary

Term	Meaning
Bleed	Extra colour or image beyond the trim line, so that printed edges look complete after cutting.
Brand Kit	Canva's storage for a brand's logos, colours and fonts (paid feature).
Brief	The client's description of the goal, audience, content and deadline.
Case study	A portfolio piece that explains the problem, process and result.
CMYK / RGB	Colour models: RGB for screens; CMYK for most commercial printing.
Contrast ratio	The difference in brightness between text and background; higher is easier to read.
DPI / PPI	Dots or pixels per inch. Print often uses 300 DPI; screens use pixels.
Gig	A service listing on a marketplace such as Fiverr.
Hierarchy	The order in which the eye reads items, set by size, weight, colour and position.
Kerning / leading	Spacing between two letters (kerning) and between lines of text (leading).
Licence	Permission to use someone else's work, with limits on how and where.
Mockup	A realistic preview showing a design on a product or screen.
Raster / vector	Pixel-based images (photos) and shape-based images (logos) that scale without losing quality.
Retainer	A fixed monthly payment for an agreed amount of ongoing work.
Template	A ready-made design that users change with their own content.
Two-step verification	A second sign-in check, such as a code from an app or text message.
White space	Empty space around and between elements that helps readability.

14.4 Final checklist

Area	Ready when…	Done
Canva account	Two-step verification is on and you can sign in on a new device	☐
Skills	You can build a social post, flyer, resume and presentation from a brief	☐
Portfolio	Eight pieces, case-study captions, one-page PDF, and a link	☐
Brand	One name, one photo, one palette, one bio across profiles	☐
Pricing	Your minimum rate is calculated and you have three packages	☐
Clients	Outreach has started, and you can explain a proposal in two minutes	☐

Marketplaces	Profile complete on at least one platform; scam warning signs understood	☐
Legal and money	Contract and invoice templates ready; local registration checked	☐
Licences	You know the licence for every template, photo and font you use	☐
Habits	Weekly routine running; records kept; one day off each week	☐

14.5 Closing words

Canva made design accessible to millions of people. Your advantage is not the software; it is the care you bring to each client's message. Start small, keep your promises, keep improving, and let your work speak for you. Every professional designer began with a first poster that they would redo today. Make the next one this week.